

Psalms 140

Deliver Me from the Evil Man

Deliver me, O Lord, from the evil man; preserve me from the violent man

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Deliver me, O LORD, from the evil man; preserve me from the violent man;*
- 2 *Which imagine mischiefs in their heart; continually are they gathered together for war.*
- 3 *They have sharpened their tongues like a serpent; adders' poison is under their lips. Selah.*
- 4 *Keep me, O LORD, from the hands of the wicked; preserve me from the violent man; who have purposed to overthrow my goings.*
- 5 *The proud have hid a snare for me, and cords; they have spread a net by the wayside; they have set gins for me. Selah.*
- 6 *I said unto the LORD, Thou art my God: hear the voice of my supplications, O LORD.*
- 7 *O GOD the Lord, the strength of my salvation, thou hast covered my head in the day of battle.*
- 8 *Grant not, O LORD, the desires of the wicked: further not his wicked device; lest they exalt themselves. Selah.*
- 9 *As for the head of those that compass me about, let the mischief of their own lips cover them.*
- 10 *Let burning coals fall upon them: let them be cast into the fire; into deep pits, that they rise not up again.*
- 11 *Let not an evil speaker be established in the earth: evil shall hunt the violent man to overthrow him.*
- 12 *I know that the LORD will maintain the cause of the afflicted, and the right of the poor.*
- 13 *Surely the righteous shall give thanks unto thy name: the upright shall dwell in thy presence.*

2 · CONTEXT

David prays for protection from calculated, verbal, and physical hostility—men who devise mischief, sharpen their tongues like serpents, and set hidden traps for his feet. The psalm moves through vivid imagery of predatory speech and concealed snares before turning to confident trust that God maintains the cause of the afflicted. Henry notes how much of the danger described here is relational and verbal rather than purely physical, a reminder that malicious speech can be as dangerous as violence.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-5

The opening plea names both evil and violent men who continually devise mischief and stir up wars, sharpening their tongues like a serpent and carrying viper's poison under their lips. Beyond speech, they set hidden snares, cords, and traps along David's path—danger described as both verbal and physically concealed.

Verse 6-8

A confession interrupts the description of threat: 'you are my God,' David declares, asking God to hear his supplications, to withhold granting the wicked their desires, and to keep their schemes from succeeding lest they grow proud.

Verse 9-11

David prays that the trouble his enemies planned for him would instead fall back on their own heads—burning coals, being cast into fire or deep pits from which they cannot rise. He asks that the slanderer find no lasting place in the land and that calamity actively hunt down the violent man.

Verse 12-13

The psalm resolves in confidence rather than continued fear: the Lord maintains the cause of the afflicted and executes justice for the poor. On that basis, David is certain the righteous will give thanks and the upright will dwell in God's presence—vindication trusted even before it visibly arrives.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Malicious speech and hidden schemes are treated here with the same seriousness as outright violence, and the appropriate response is neither retaliation nor despair but specific prayer entrusting justice to God. Confidence that God maintains the cause of the afflicted allows the psalmist to move from vivid fear to settled trust without needing to see the threat actually resolved first.

Application for life today.

If you are currently facing manipulative speech or hidden hostility, let this psalm's specificity give you language for naming that danger honestly to God rather than minimizing it. Resist the pull toward retaliation by handing the outcome to God, as David does in verses 9–11, trusting Him to address what you cannot control. Let verse 12's confidence—that God maintains the cause of the afflicted—anchor your trust even while the situation itself remains unresolved.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What form of hidden or verbal hostility in your life does this psalm's imagery of serpents and snares (vv. 1–5) help you name more honestly?

2. Where are you tempted toward retaliation rather than entrusting the outcome to God, as David does in verses 9–11?

3. How does verse 12's confidence that God maintains the cause of the afflicted shape your trust in a situation that still feels unresolved?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).